



Taher speaking at the recent VLSID conference held in Bengaluru

Once again, responsibilities presided over aspirations. Taher respected his father's decision and enrolled in an engineering programme. But even as an engineering student, his mind constantly worked on ways to sustain himself. While his peers were busy forming friendship bonds, Taher was consumed with a more significant concern—survival. “I had no money. My biggest worry was how to earn while studying. Since I joined Aligarh Muslim University late in the academic year, I had to quickly find a way to earn while maintaining my grades and attendance. I needed to find students, but this was a new city where no one knew me,” he says.

Instead of befriending classmates, he strategically built relationships with decision-makers — the warden, professors, and school administrators. Within three weeks, he had secured his first tutoring job, teaching a teacher's child from Lady Fatima School, one of the most prestigious schools in Aligarh.

“That was my breakthrough. Once I started teaching her children, she recommended me to others,” he shares. This network of students kept growing, and before long, he was once again balancing a full-fledged tutoring business alongside his engineering studies.

“My classes would finish at 3 pm. I would then return to my hostel and cook *dal-chawal* or quickly gobble a couple of *rotis* and *sabzi* delivered from the kitchen, and by 4pm I was out again, teaching students till 10pm. I did this every single day for five years. When you have responsibilities beyond yourself, you stop making excuses. You just do what needs to be done,” he reflects, pausing to wipe his moist eyes.

His childhood burdens never gave Taher the luxury of dreaming for himself, but dreams have a way of slipping into the mind, uninvited yet persistent. For Taher, a poster of the New York skyline hanging in the college canteen drew stars in his eyes, which up until now hadn't even gotten a chance to tear up amidst adversity. Every time he sat there, his eyes would drift toward it, mesmerised by its magnificence. “*Ek din wahaan toh jaana hi hai!*” he would think to himself. The boy who had once been consumed by survival now dared to dream of the Big Apple.

He had a dream; he worked for it

By the time he reached the final years of his engineering degree, something had changed. Initially, I was just trying to survive. But as I

became more comfortable managing my studies and work, I started thinking about what came next,” he says. While many of his classmates aspired to become bureaucrats—several went on to become IAS and IPS officers—Taher's aspirations differed. He wanted to build something of his own. This was the beginning of a mindset shift—from survival to leadership. He realised that success was not just about working hard but about working strategically.

While the New York skyline continued to beckon Taher in his dreams, fate refused to let him off easy. His first attempt at securing a visa was unsuccessful, forcing him to rethink his approach. In the meantime, he took a job at an HCL subsidiary in New Delhi, earning just 1400 rupees per month—less than what he had made as a tutor. As a part of the research and development team at HCL, Taher worked on building computer designs and learning about how global technology companies operated.

Over the next two years, his salary increased from 1400 rupees to 6000 rupees per month. “For someone who had struggled with money all his life, that felt like a fortune,” he recalls.

“If you want to grow, start performing at the next level before